Teaching and Teacher Education 52 (2015) 1–10

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Teaching and Teacher Education

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/tate

A closer look at the role of mentor teachers in shaping preservice teachers' professional identity

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HIGHLIGHTS

- The impact of mentoring relationship on professional identity of seven preservice was examined.
- When the mentoring relationship was positive the confidence level grew in the participants.
- But some participants experienced negative mentoring relationship and they felt less like a teacher at the end of the course.

ARTICLE INFO

Article history:
Received 22 January 2015
Received in revised form
27 July 2015
Accepted 4 August 2015
Available online 13 August 2015

Keywords:
Teacher professional identity
Mentoring relationship
Preservice teachers
Teacher education

ABSTRACT

This paper focuses on the extent to which mentoring relationships played a role in creating changes in the professional identity of seven preservice teachers. Semi-structured interviews, observations and reflective journals were used to document the changes experienced by participants as they went through their two placements during their one-year teacher education course. The data indicated that when the mentoring relationships were positive and expectations were met, preservice teachers felt more confident as a teacher. However, for some participants, who experienced a partially negative mentoring relationship, their confidence declined and they felt they did not improve. Implications for practice are discussed.

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1. Introduction

Statistics show a 50% attrition rate for beginning teachers within their first five years of teaching in developed countries (Ingersoll, 2003; Jonson, 2002; Ramsey, 2000). In Australia, Ewing and Manuel (2005) observed that up to one third of teachers left the profession in their first three to five years of service. While factors such as workload, school situation, and salary have affected the teachers' decisions to leave (Smithers & Robinson, 2003), early positive experiences in teacher education have been considered strong motivational forces in continuing to teach (Ewing & Manuel, 2005). For instance, feeling valued, the perception of success, and a sense of worth correlate with retention (Blase, 2009; Dyson, Albon, & Hutchinson, 2007).

According to He (2009), the mentoring experience is a key factor in the success of beginning teachers. It is also believed that the presence of a mentor increases the retention of beginning teachers (Ingersoll & Smith, 2003; Lortie, 1975; Odell & Ferraro, 1992). The literature abounds with studies on the teaching practice unit (practicum) and within that the role of mentor teachers (i.e. those who supervise preservice teachers in their practicum setting, Beck and Kosnik (2000)) in early professional development of preservice teachers (Chaliès, Ria, Bertone, Trohel, & Durand, 2004; Glenn, 2006; Leshem, 2012; Martin, Snow, & Torrez, 2011). The extensive research on mentoring suggests that mentoring as one factor impacting retention has deserved a great deal of attention of researchers at international level. Pascarelli (1998); for example, writes about the different roles of mentor teachers changing from showing empathy and giving advice to empowering the mentees and highlighting their personal strengths. Other researchers discuss the components of good mentoring programs, such as communication, authenticity, encouraging gestures, honesty, trust, constructive feedback, and emotional and academic support (Izadinia, 2015; Beck & Kosnik, 2002; Zanting, Verloop, & Vermunt, 2001).

As there is broad agreement on the important role of mentor teachers in preservice teacher education (Beck & Kosnik, 2000), it is

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http://dx.doi.org/10.1016/j.tate.2015.08.003
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of utmost significance to research the dynamics of "this sometimes fraught relationship" (Patrick, 2013, p. 209) and its contribution to the professional lives of preservice teachers. Recently, more research has focused on the interaction between mentors and preservice teachers (Ambrosetti & Dekkers, 2010; Bradbury & Koballa, 2008; Ferrier-Kerr, 2009), yet little is still known about the role of mentoring relationships in the development of teacher identity in preservice teachers (Izadinia, 2013) .

Teacher identity as a determining factor in teacher motivation, satisfaction, and commitment to work (Day, Kington, Stobart, & Sammons, 2006), also contributes to teacher retention and lack thereof leads to teacher stress and burnout (Hellman, 2007; Scheib, 2007). The dynamic and constantly evolving nature of teacher identity (Beijaard, Meijer, & Verloop, 2004) shapes in an examination of the self in interaction with others in a professional context (Beauchamp & Thomas, 2009). For instance, research shows that involvement of preservice teachers in learning communities and activities such as reflective writing and collaborative reflection inform preservice teachers' professional identity (Cattley, 2007; Estola, 2003; Vavrus, 2009; Webb, 2005). The growing number of studies on factors contributing to the formation of teacher identity in preservice teachers suggests that the development of a teacher identity is a central process in becoming a teacher (Alsup, 2005; Friesen & Besley, 2013). Moreover, having a strong sense of identity, as discussed above, contributes to teacher retention as it helps beginning teachers to gain a sense of control and remain resilient (Bieler, 2013).

Johnson (2003), argues that the relationship between a mentor teacher and a preservice teacher can transform the teachers involved. In other words, mentor teachers can inform the development of teacher identity in preservice teachers by instilling in them a sense of confidence, power and agency (Liu & Fisher, 2006; Ticknor, 2014; Williams, 2010) or, conversely, inhibiting the development of their voice (Beck & Kosnik, 2000; Patrick, 2013; Pittard, 2003). There are a handful of studies on the impact of mentoring on identity formation of preservice teachers. For instance, in the US, Bieler (2013) used a holistic mentoring approach with four student teachers to explore all the factors that contributed to their professional identity development. She described how three holistic mentoring moves-creating an opening for the new teachers' voices, listening for and inquiring into holistic possibilities, and cultivating holistic, agentive teaching, and learning practices-helped her students to forge and voice their identities.

Pillen, Den Brok, and Beijaard (2013) explored the tensions in the professional identity of beginning teachers in the Netherlands and found that the support and activities provided by teacher educators and mentor teachers reduced or altered their tensions. In another case study conducted in the UK (Liu & Fisher, 2006), positive changes in three foreign language student teachers' conceptions of their identity and classroom performance were observed; the preservice teachers perceived that they made improvement in their teaching practice throughout the year and they felt more like a 'real' teacher due to factors such as accumulation of experience and support from their mentors. This study, among other things, showed the impact of a positive relationship between teacher educators and student teachers on teacher change and professional growth. In previous research in Australia the author examined the impact of mentoring relationships on eight preservice teachers' teacher identity during a four-week block practicum and it was found that positive mentoring relationship and mentors' feedback significantly contributed to changes in aspects of professional identity such as the participants' teacher voice, confidence and vision.

The present research aims to further investigate the changes in the above-mentioned participants' teacher identity as they moved through their subsequent seven-week block practicum and experienced a different mentoring relationship. By comparing the dynamics of the mentoring relationships and the changes in participants' teacher identity in the two placements, the author sought to identify the significance of the mentor teachers' roles in the professional lives of the preservice teachers. It was also assumed that by giving voice to preservice teachers' mentoring experiences, extra caution will be exercised by teacher education programs to train mentor teachers who are well aware of their crucial role in shaping preservice teachers' professional identity. The key question raised in this study is: How does the relationship between mentor teachers and preservice teachers influence the development of preservice teachers' professional identities during a one year Graduate Diploma of Education-Secondary program? The sub questions addressed in this study are:

1. How did preservice teachers characterize the mentoring relationship in the first and second practicum?
2. What changes occurred in the preservice teachers' professional identity following the second placement?
3. To what extent did mentor teachers in the two placements play a role in shaping the preservice teachers' teacher identity?

2. Theoretical framework

Professional identity construction as a learning-to-teach process (Smagorinsky, Cook, Moore, Jackson, & Fry, 2004) occurs as preservice teachers interact with significant others such as their teacher educators (Johnson, 2003). Such a view is based on social constructivism, which assumes learning happens in a social process in which learners gain new skills and knowledge through interactions with other people such as teachers (Vygotsky, 1978). It was assumed that a social constructivist approach would adequately guide the study to examine how pre-service teachers' professional identity would be affected by their interactions with mentor teachers because its three main tenets could be easily applied to a mentoring relationship (Graves, 2010). In other words, the three tenets of (1) knowledge is constructed by learners; (2) learning involves social interaction and (3) learning is situated (Beck & Kosnik, 2006) can be interpreted as: pre-service teachers go through the learning-to-teach process and gradually construct their teacher identity in their daily interactions with significant others, such as their mentor teachers in the context of the practicum.

3. Method

3.1. Context of the study

The study was conducted in the Graduate Diploma of Education-Secondary (GDE-S) Course, in the School of Education at a university in Western Australia. The programs offered by the School of Education are informed by the Australian Curriculum, Assessment and Reporting Authority (ACARA), which is responsible for the development of a national curriculum, assessment, and a data collection and reporting program that supports learning for all Australian students. Along with ACARA, the Australian Institute for Teaching and School Leadership (AITSL) also provides national leadership for Commonwealth, state and territory governments and promotes excellence in teaching and school leadership.

The GDE-S, the context of the study, is designed to prepare students for the Secondary Education profession and the graduates are eligible to teach in secondary schools. This course is a one-year

program, which has 120 credit points, is accredited by the Teacher Registration Board of Western Australia, and is offered via two modes of delivery: on-campus and residency. The focus of this study was on on-campus students.

The professional identity of preservice teachers who took part in GDE-S were under the influence of different factors in their learning community. As explained above, ACARA and AITSL impacted preservice teachers' identity with their proposed curriculums and rules. Apart from that, preservice teachers came from different disciplines, bringing with them prior experiences and backgrounds that had already begun to shape their teacher identity. Equally significant was the role of university lecturers and school contexts during practicum and within that mentor teachers who had constant and direct interactions with preservice teachers. Acknowledging the overriding importance of all these factors on the process of identity construction of the participants, the present research focused on the impact of the last factor (i.e. mentor teachers' role) on preservice teachers' professional identity construction.

3.2. Participants

The preservice teachers who volunteered to take part in this research comprised five females and two males from the two disciplines of music (five) and drama (two) and in an age range of early 20s to early 30s. Initially there were eight participants. However, in the second semester one participant from the discipline of drama withdrew from the research. All participants were enrolled in the GDE-S by March 2014; they were recruited for the research either during orientation day or in the first week of the program. All participants volunteered to take part in the research study knowing that their names and any identifiable information would be removed from the data, they would be assigned pseudonyms, and they would be able to withdraw from the research at any time.

The placements of the preservice teachers to schools were made through the university's practicum office. Each participant was assigned one main mentor teacher in each placement. However, some participants had the chance to observe and work with more than one mentor teachers.

3.3. Data sources

Data collection occurred over the course of the one-year GDE-S program. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with each preservice teacher at three different stages: in early March 2014, after the end of the first placement in July, and at the end of the second placement in early December. The first interview dealt with questions such as: What is your purpose of teaching? Do you have a vision of the kind of teacher you would like to be? What are your main responsibilities toward your students? The questions in the second and third interviews were mainly about the mentoring experiences and any perceived changes in participants' teacher identity, such as: Could you describe the relationship you shared with your mentor teacher? Do you think your mentor gave you the courage and confidence you needed in your role? Can you compare the relationship you shared with your mentors in the first and second practicum? Which one did you prefer and why? The interviews, which lasted 15–50 min, were all audio recorded and transcribed verbatim (Please see Appendix for the interview questions).

The participants were also invited to keep a reflective journal as they went through their course. One participant chose not to write a journal due to time limitations, but the other participants produced at least three journal entries: one during the first semester, one during the first placement, and one at the end of the first placement. In the second placement only four of the preservice teachers continued to write, adding one more entry to their journal. Thus, a total of 24 reflective journals was gathered over the course of the program. The participants were asked to write about issues such as their experiences of teaching within their schools, their ideas about the mentoring relationship, their perceptions of their progress, and whether they detected any changes in their teacher identity. However, they were also given the leeway to write about any other issues of interest and significance to them.

In addition to interviews and reflective journals, an observation checklist was used to pinpoint the dynamics of the interactions between the preservice teachers and their mentors. Items such as “way of giving feedback”, “collaboration”, “giving confidence”, and “open communication” were among the items on the checklist. The frequencies of the actions, as well as examples of behaviour, were recorded by the researcher during the observations. Two classroom observations were conducted on each participant's teaching practices in each placement. Since the unit of analysis was the interaction between mentors and mentees, and given that there was not much interaction between them during mentees' solo teaching, the researcher also attended debriefing sessions following each solo teaching. The checklist and notes helped the researcher to identify specific patterns of interactions between the participants. For example, the ease of communication and the way verbal and written feedback was offered indicated the extent to which rapport, respect, and support was provided and established. The debriefing sessions, lasted 3–30 min, depending on the extent of the feedback and the length of conversations between mentors and mentees.

3.4. Data analysis

Analysis was conducted in two stages based on guidelines suggested by Merriam (1998). Initially, each participant's data, (i.e. their transcribed interviews, reflective journals, observation checklists and researcher's notes) were read over and over again and analysed independently (within-case analysis) to build a profile of each participant's prior experiences, unique mentoring experiences, and challenges during the one-year course. Questions asked in analysing each set of data included: What mentoring experiences were significant to this person? How did this person's experience influence their identity? How did this person feel when they remembered their mentors and the mentoring experience? Did they feel motivated, inspired, happy or the opposite? Observation checklists and researcher's notes helped in crosschecking the data. More specifically, the participants' comments on the availability of their mentors or the depth of their feedback were compared to the notes taken in the debriefing sessions for verification. For instance, the researcher took note of the length of sessions and noticed some sessions were as short as 3 minutes and some mentors were not present during the two solo teaching of the preservice teachers that the researcher observed. Such data provided further evidence for the mentors' patterns of interaction with their mentees.

Based on the initial within-case analysis some codes were developed and then the codes were compared across cases (cross-case analysis). The two stages of analysis were done with a focus on how the participants' teacher identities were influenced and developed as a result of their mentoring experiences. Constant comparison techniques provided the chance to compare each case with others to determine similarities and differences (Merriam, 1998). However, as Patton (2002) suggests “the analyst's first and foremost responsibility consists of doing justice to each individual case. All else depends on that” (p.449). Thus, an attempt was made to delve deeply into each participant's experiences and provide more detailed within-case analysis in this paper. In the last stage,

data were grouped together and the most recurring codes were regarded as themes, with the most telling or representative extracts selected for reporting.

3.5. Limitations

Although the richness of the data helped to identify factors which can impact future research and practice, there are a number of limitations to this study. First, there are a number of factors at play to inform pre-service teachers' identity formation in a learning community like the practicum. While the significance of all these factors, including the role of other members of the community and the school context is acknowledged, the present research only considered the impact of the mentoring relationships on the pre-service teachers' identity formation. Therefore, some changes in pre-service teacher identity might have occurred due to other external factors which were not examined in this research. Second, given that the preservice teachers participating in this research were very busy with their course, the researcher could not ask them to check the conclusion of the study for verification. However, the researcher tried to enhance the credibility of the data (Guba & Lincoln, 1989) through other triangulation strategies (Denzin, 1989) such as collecting the data from different sources (preservice teachers and mentor teachers), time (at the beginning and end of each placement) and methods (interviews, observations, reflective journals).

4. Results

In analysing the data, the researcher was particularly interested in emotions associated with the mentoring experiences of the participants. Emotion is "a dimension of the self and a factor that has a bearing on the expression of identity and the shaping of it" (Beauchamp & Thomas, 2009, p. 180). Beauchamp and Thomas (2009), quoting Zembylas (2003) argue that the emotions teachers experience in particular contexts "expand or limit [their] possibilities" in teaching (Zembylas, 2003, p. 122). It was assumed that by focussing on the emotions related to the mentoring experiences, further changes in teacher identity resulting in changes in participants' teaching practices could be tranced (Beijaard et al., 2004).

The primary stages of the analysis revealed two sets of experiences for the participants. One comprised four preservice teachers, who had experienced very positive mentoring relationships in both two placements; the other was three participants who had not enjoyed their mentoring relationship in the second placement as much as they did in the first (For a detailed explanation about the participants' first placement experience refer to Author's subsequent work).

4.1. Components of good mentoring relationship: were the expectations met?

It was discussed in previous research (Izadinia, 2015), conducted prior to the first placement, that encouragement and support, open communication and feedback were the three main components of a good mentoring relationship for preservice teachers participating in this study. The analysis of interviews at the end of the first placement revealed that all the participants were extremely satisfied with their mentoring relationships, as the mentor teachers had surpassed their expectations. Four participants, Liz, Linda, Chelsey, and Sara, (same pseudonyms are used in all studies), found the second placement to be another positive experience.

Liz, went into the first placement hoping to have a mentor teacher who "is not intimidating" or "too stuck in their ways". She found her first mentor to be "never overly critical" and felt "quite blessed" because her mentor let her "handle things on [her] way" and "incorporate [her] ideas into doing things". In the last interview at the end of the second placement, Liz expressed again that she "got so much independence" and her second mentor similarly provided the chance for her to "step into that role of authority" in the class:

> About halfway through the second week … he [the second mentor] started more and more often just removing himself from the room into his office. So he was still close enough to hear if anything went drastically wrong but it helped me sort of step into that role of authority a bit more and learn how to deal with being the only figure of authority in the room.

The extracts indicate that having an open and friendly mentor who let Liz "debate and test different ideas" freely and feel like an authority, was initially very significant for her. Some researchers also suggest that open communication is one of the main ingredients to successful mentoring (Beyene, Anglin, Sanchez, & Ballou, 2002) and preservice teachers can develop the confidence to express themselves when mentor teachers show openness to their ideas (Liliane & Colette, 2009). These findings are supported by Liz's experience of feeling like an authority at the end of the second placement as her both mentor teachers let her experiment her ideas and encouraged her to be independent. When talking about her mentors in both placements, Liz frequently used positive adjectives to describe her mentoring experiences: "he [the first mentor] really did a good job", "I feel blessed", "he was extremely organized", "he [the second mentor] was amazing", "I was really lucky with both my pracs". Ticknor (2014) contends "emotion and cognition impact identities in positive and productive ways that allow for professional confidence and thoughtful decision making by novice teachers" (p. 301). As the above quotes suggest, Liz experienced complete satisfaction with her practicum experiences. At the end of her final interview, Liz concluded: "if I ever mentor students myself in a few years' time as a teacher …, I am pretty much going to model what I do off what [the second mentor] did with me". Feeling pleased with the mentoring experience and happy with her progress, Liz, as will be explained below, grew highly confident as a new teacher.

For Linda, the mentoring experience in both placements was also very positive. Emphasizing the 'support' aspect of mentoring relationship, Linda remarked before the start of the placements that mentors should try to be supportive because "that is what they are supposed to be". In the second interview, when asked for any significant experience during the first placement, Linda stated she received the same level of support she expected. She explained that after delivering an "absolutely awful" lesson, where "everything got on top of [her]", she had a chat with her mentor teacher:

> … and I said, "It was awful, these two lessons", and she was absolutely bombarding me, "Everybody has it, you know, you just take it on board, get up," and she was just feeding me with positive reinforcement, which helped so much.

In her second placement, Linda had another supportive mentor who was always there for her and available "even on the weekends". Linda mentioned that "[the mentor] never said anything I did was wrong, so when I came and showed her [the lesson plans] she was like, 'Oh, add that, add that,' but never like, 'Oh, that is not good enough,' she trusted me".

Providing academic and emotional support has been recognized as another key component of a mentoring relationship for preservice teachers in a number of studies (Beck & Kosnik, 2002; Ferrier-Kerr, 2009; Jacobi, 1991; Rajuan, Beijaard, & Verloop, 2007). Rajuan

et al. (2007), for instance, observe that maintaining a collaborative and supportive relationship with mentees help them develop the confidence to take risks and experiment in the classroom. Equally significant, the role of emotional support has received even more attention in the literature (Izadinia, 2015; Caires & Almeida, 2007; Rajuan et al., 2007). Pitton (2006), argue that beginning teachers feel overwhelmingly stressed simply because they are new; therefore, mentor teachers need to acknowledge the emotions that mentees experience and support them emotionally. In this study, as Linda asserted, feeling emotionally supported by her mentor and knowing that her mentor was there for her "all the time" helped Linda build up her confidence and get over the discomfort she felt. Similar to Liz, Linda believed her mentor in the second placement "was amazing and everything [Linda] could imagine she [the mentor] did.

Chelsey and Sara had similar experiences in their second placement. They also mentioned positive features of their mentoring experiences, such as "frank feedback", receiving "a lot of time and attention and resources", and "supportive relationship founded on mutual respect and professionalism". Sara, when referring to her first placement, wrote in her journal that she "felt a strong sense of belonging" and she "grew enormously" during her fist placement thanks to her mentor teacher. Sara's second mentor was also "absolutely fantastic" and "genuinely cared" about her and her feedback, which was "always excellent and massively detailed", provided "incredible" support and encouragement for her. Use of words such as "fantastic', 'excellent', and 'incredible' indicates Sara's positive perception of the mentoring experience and overall satisfaction with it.

As mentioned above, for the other three participants, Anna, Simon and Eden, the second placement was not as positive as the first one. Coming out of the first placement, Anna, Simon and Eden felt very satisfied with their mentoring experiences in which they had "strong personal relationship" and "good rapport" with their mentors. Having expressed a need for "support-based" mentoring and "an inspiring role model" who could "impart knowledge", Simon was delighted to find his first mentor was "a fantastic and accomplished musician" who had a "high status in the profession". During the first placement, the mentor showed "a lot of faith" in Simon, "really valued [his] input, ideas and expertise" and "was able to trust" him. Simon wrote in his journal at the end of the first placement that his experience was "extremely positive" and his strong relationship with his mentor "contributed immensely" to his success during the practicum.

Conversely, in the second placement, the mentor teacher "did not shut [Simon] down or anything, but she did not really value the expertise [he] had". Simon who had been given "a lot of freedom" to "develop [his] ideas" … and "construct creative lessons" in the first placement, felt "quite frustrated" and it "damaged [his] confidence" when his second mentor "would often step in to manage behaviour or to direct the class". In addition, Simon pointed out that "a lot of things that [the mentor] was doing were … examples of bad teaching". He explained that his mentor "was very traditional", "very rote learning", "she would yell at a lot of students" and the answers she gave to the questions "were just completely wrong". Therefore, even though Simon thought his second mentor "was really nice, really friendly, and really supportive", he did not think that he "had it [a mentoring relationship] at all with her and she was not the kind of teacher that [he] want to be in 10 or 20 years":

> It was just kind of hard to respect someone or see someone as a mentor when I think in a lot of ways, I do not say I could do things better than her, but I understood the things she was doing was really quite wrong and different from what we were kind of told at the uni.

Having the freedom to try out teaching ideas has been recognized as a critical factor to preservice teachers' professional learning (Patrick, 2013) and lack thereof can lead to tensions on their part. As Simon's words 'quite frustrated' show, he lived through the tension of having no freedom to manage the class on his own because his mentor constantly stepped in and thereby 'damaged' his confidence. In addition, having an inspiring role model was an important feature of a mentor according to Simon. Several researchers have claimed that role modelling is among the essential qualities of a good mentor (Jacobi, 1991; Koerner, Rust, & Baumgartner, 2002). In other words, preservice teachers need mentors who can provide examples of good practice for them to evaluate and emulate (Koerner et al., 2002). If mentor teachers do not have the required skills in mentoring, this can have a negative impact on preservice teachers' professional development (Weasmer & Woods, 2003). Simon felt he did not have a mentoring relationship with his mentor because he could not accept her as a role model for the teacher he wanted to be in the future.

Anna was struggling to find her teacher self from the very beginning. She wrote in her journal before the first placement that "I find it hard to differentiate myself from the students as I feel I could dress up in the uniform and be one myself". For Anna what mattered the most was her mentor's support so she could feel secured to try to develop her teacher voice. Fortunately, Anna's first mentor "was very supportive of everything [she] kind of did", and "was really there for [her]". In the interview conducted at the end of the first placement, Anna mentioned she felt "more like a teacher" and has developed a voice. However, Anna did not think she had a "strong bond" with her second mentor. Describing the relationship as "a little more distant", Anna explained that her second mentor was not as much supportive and helpful: "she was not always present and when she was present she always had other things on her mind and was doing other tasks, so was a little bit vague". Comparing her first mentor with the second one, Anna explained:

> When I would finish a lesson, she [the second mentor] would quickly disappear because she had gone to … have lunch" and I would be there packing up … but my [first] mentor was always there waiting or watching or helping me pack up.

Anna felt she "did not have a mentor at times because it was just me there, just doing my thing". This absence was noted in the Researcher's observation notes about Anna's teaching. Anna was left on her own for most of the sessions, while the mentor teacher was either not present or deeply involved in her personal tasks. Draves (2008) maintains that the rapport between mentor teachers and preservice teachers determines the overall success of a practicum. As identified by other researchers (Ferrier-Kerr, 2009), it is of utmost importance for preservice teachers to make a personal connection with their mentor teachers. Moreover, the presence of a strong emotional connection results in better outcomes, such as perception of scholastic competence and feelings of self-worth (Deutsch & Spencer, 2009). On the contrary, relationships that are not close have little effect (DuBois & Neville, 1997; Grossman & Rhodes, 2002). Anna used the word "distant" to describe her second mentoring relationship, which suggests a lack of personal connection between the two parties and a degree of exclusion on Anna's part which meant she "did not feel welcomed".

Similar to Simon and Anna, Eden experienced a "partially negative" second mentoring relationship in which he felt "frustrated a lot". For Eden receiving continuous feedback from mentor teachers was very important; and what significantly contributed to his improvement in the first placement was "the cycle of teach, feedback, reflect and act on feedback". However, in the second placement, Eden remarked: "I did reflect, just as before, and I did

get feedback, but those things were disconnected. She [the second mentor] never was interested in seeing my reflection". Failing to make a connection between experiences Eden gained in the first and second placements, the second mentor encouraged Eden to forget everything he did in the previous school, because she believed "it [the school] is different, we are different, everything is different here". Eden claimed that when the skills he had developed in the first placement were not recognized and valued by his second mentor he "did not use them anymore" and he "forgot they were there" and "the more [he] did that the less successful [he] was". Thus, he felt his individual strengths were "magically" taken away from him and he "did not exist as a teacher"; "it is almost like, if you take your superpowers away from your superman you are just left as kind of not able to do all the things that you would normally do".

Eden who had also enjoyed a good rapport with his first mentor, felt him and his second mentor "were like two separate people, with two separate roles", and they did not have "too much in common" which "affected [them] quite a lot". Referring to the profound influence of mentor teachers on the success of mentees and the necessity of mentor training, Eden recommended mentoring should not be left to chance:

> If you realize that one of the main things that is affecting people's success is, do they get along with their mentor, you need to remove that … In any other industry, if you train someone, you have to study that. This should be something people think about. It is just sort of the sink or swim mentoring thing. You send students to them, you say, "How is that student? Are you broken or are you happy?" And then you say, "Happy? Good. Okay, great, that worked out".

It seems reasonable to conclude that Eden's lack of rapport and personal connection with the second mentor teacher negatively influenced his teacher identity and the absence of 'negotiability' resulted in an 'identity of non-participation and marginality' (Wenger, 1998). Wenger uses the word negotiability to refer to the extent to which individuals can use, claim or modify meanings that are important to them as their own. Wenger argues that if such negotiability is absent the individual's experience "becomes irrelevant because it cannot be asserted and recognized as a form of competence" (p.203). The skills Eden acquired over the course of the first placement were discarded because they were not valued or recognized by his mentor and, thus, he formed an identity of non-participation. His comment on his identity was chilling: "I felt like I did not exist as a teacher"; "if you do not have an identity, you do not exist".

Helping preservice teachers explore their personal teaching identities (Rajuan et al., 2007) and their own teaching style (Black & Halliwell, 2000; Pajak, 2001) are among the key tasks for mentor teachers. By promoting reflection on prior experiences (Bates, Drits, & Ramirez, 2011) and new challenges, and helping him build on his strengths and adapt his already developed skills to the new school situation, the mentor teacher could help Eden form his own teacher identity. However, as shown in the above extracts, Eden's mentor exhorted him to forget his past experiences, did not highlight the importance of reflection, and failed to help him utilize his teaching skills. Therefore, instead of forging his own identity, Eden was encouraged to adopt an assigned identity (Buzzelli & Johnston, 2002): "it was almost like I was trying to become her [the mentor]".

4.2. Changes in teacher identity

Korthagen (2004) claims that "fundamental changes in teacher identity do not take place easily: identity change is a difficult and sometimes painful process, and often there seems to be little change at all in how teachers view themselves" (p. 85). Likewise, Borko and Mayfield (1995) assert that "big" changes did not occur in their student teachers' beliefs about teaching and learning or their basic teaching strategies and styles. Arguably, the present study added support to these findings because no fundamental changes happened in the participants' teacher identity; only small changes were observed. Drawing on Kelchtermans (1993)'s conceptualization of teacher professional identity (i.e. self-image, self-esteem, job motivation, task-perception and future perspective), the resesarcher asked the participants to, for instance, describe themselves as a teacher (self-image), and their main responsibilities as a teacher (task perception) in each round of interviews. The results showed that some participants slightly changed their views about their role as a teacher over the course of the program. For instance, Chelsey said in the first interview that she "want[s] kids to enjoy learning", "think critically" and "find their talents and strength". Then in the final interview, Chelsey stated:

> I think my responsibilities are two-fold: Creating interesting, engaging and relevant content to teach, and building positive relationships with my students. I think the two areas are linked. Students respond better to teachers who take the time to get to know them, and try to meet their needs.

Thus, by the end of the practicum Chelsey favoured a holistic view of education as opposed to the traditional paradigm. Whereas the cognitive aspect is the main focus in traditional schooling, in holistic education students are viewed as a whole being with emotional and social elements to consider (Miller, 2000; Nava, 2001). For Liz, the learning outcomes came to matter most. She had initially intended to help her students "be the best person they can be" and "lift them up when they need that". At the end of the program, Liz proclaimed she should make sure "they [the students] know the content" because "generally" they should "behave and learn". Simon's perception of his role also changed. He remarked in his first interview that he felt his vision had already changed after a few weeks of being in the program:

> Before beginning this course I thought it was to impart musical knowledge and to make sure students have fun and do it in a safe and creative way but I guess for the past couple of weeks I've been doing a lot of reading and it's like a huge responsibility now … we're really an active part in their developmental upbringing.

In the final interview, Simon referred to "fostering a real love of music" and engaging the students as his main responsibilities. For the rest of the participants no significant changes were observed in their perceptions of their role and responsibilities and the way they perceived themselves as a teacher.

However, there was a noticeable change in participants' level of confidence. Izadinia (2013) identified confidence as a component of preservice teachers' professional identity. It was found in this study that the confidence level changed as the participants moved from their first placement to the second. Whereas all participants reported they felt quite confident at the end of the first placement, those who had a positive mentoring experience in the second placement grew more confident, and those who had a negative experience grew less confident. For instance, Chelsey referred to the significant contribution of her mentor in boosting her confidence, declaring "I am a more confident teacher" and feel more comfortable exercising my authority". Sara and Liz similarly believed they felt "like a teacher" at the end of the second

placement. Liz remarked: "I feel less like a student standing up in front of a bunch of other students trying to pretend to be a teacher … I felt that shift between trying to be a teacher and actually being a teacher". Sara stated she did not feel she was necessarily more confident but she knew "how to fake it better". She believed she "developed a good repertoire of non-verbals and that helped a lot with showing power and control".

Yet, for Simon, Anna and Eden, whose second placement was not positive, their confidence definitely declined. They referred to situations and instances when they felt the second mentoring relationship had specifically damaged their confidence. As explained above, Simon said the way his mentor teacher interfered with his teaching to manage behaviour "shot down [his] confidence and courage" at times. Anna, believing she did not improve as much as the first placement, claimed that not receiving "the sort of response or feedback or support from [her] mentor as the first one … lowered [her] confidence". Eden, feeling confident after the end of the first placement in a way that he "felt like [he] could just turn around and come back and teach there", lamented that he "did not improve" as much as he did with his first mentor. He believed the mentoring experience "undermined the confidence [he] had".

Carrington, Kervin, and Ferry (2011) reinforce that a degree of self-confidence contribute to the progression of teacher professional identity and a supportive field experience during preservice teacher education is highly significant. The results of this study corresponded with this finding. As Anna indicated, not receiving enough support from her mentor made her feel she did not have a mentor, and the immediate impact of such feeling was that her confidence declined and she felt she did not improve as much. For Eden an obvious decrease in self-confidence was detected in his second placement. He went from feeling ready to teach in the same school to feeling he did not exist as a teacher. Given that identity development involves an understanding of the self (Beauchamp & Thomas, 2009), the way preservice teachers view themselves is bound to have a bearing on their future performance. In other words, if the mentor teachers fail to instill a sense of confidence in preservice teachers, the latter will think they are inadequate, not ready for the job and unsuited for the profession. It is possible there could be long-lasting consequences impacting their future performance or leading to attrition. The opposite holds true: having a positive self-view about oneself increases feelings of self-esteem and self-worth (Hoelter, 1986) and, as mentioned in the introduction, perception of success and a sense of worth impact future performance and lead to retention (Blase, 2009; Dyson et al., 2007). Liz; for example, developed a sense of authority and felt like a real teacher by the end of the second placement; then she demonstrated a higher teaching ability, as shown in her final evaluation.

5. Concluding remarks

Wenger (1998) emphasizes that interactions are important to identity formation. Holland, Lachicotte, and Skinner (1998), similarly maintain "what we call identities remain dependent upon social relations and material conditions. If these relations and material conditions change, they must be 'answered', and old 'answers' about who one is may be undone" (p.189). The results of this study show that although mentor teachers did not create drastic changes in preservice teachers' professional identity, they positively or negatively informed it. When the participants experienced two positive mentoring relationships in which their expectations were met, they sensed a higher level of confidence to begin their teaching career. Moreover, positive emotions, a happier disposition, and an overall positive self-image were noticed among the participants in this category. As Alsup (2005) state, developing identity includes consideration of who or what we think we are. Having positive perceptions, such as feeling confident in one's abilities as a teacher and being inspired and motivated to take on the teacher role, can significantly impact the construction of a stronger sense of identity in preservice teachers as observed in this group of participants.

Conversely, the confidence declined in other participants where mentoring relationship changed for the worse and the expectations were not realized. They felt frustrated, not welcomed, and quite unhappy with their progress. Thus, as early positive experiences in teacher education and the perception of success result in retention (Blase, 2009; Dyson et al., 2007; Ewing & Manuel, 2005), feeling less like a teacher and having a distorted self-image could negatively impact the preservice teachers' future performance or lead to attrition.

Although professional identity begins to form during the practicum, as Cattley (2007) recommends, it is best not to leave the strength of this development to chance. It was discussed above that the process of developing a teacher identity is dynamic; it starts in teacher education and continues to evolve as beginning teachers take on the role of a teacher. Teacher educators, including mentor teachers, cannot expect preservice teachers to develop into full-fledged teachers with a strong sense of teacher identity. As the data showed, only a few participants felt confident as a teacher and, to some extent, developed a teacher voice after finishing the practicum. Yet, teacher educators have a big responsibility to help preservice teachers in this formative stage of their identification.

It was mentioned that preservice teachers need to acquire a teacher identity because it plays a role in different aspects of a teacher's career including the decisions they make about their teaching practices, the content they teach, and the kind of relationships they have with their students (Beijaard et al., 2004). Given the significance of developing a teacher identity, teacher educators are recommended to ensure that preservice teachers are in the right path of finding who they are as teachers, what goals they are pursuing and what they want to achieve by being a teacher. The more confident preservice teachers feel about being a teacher, the longer they will remain in the profession. In order to maximize the possibility of retention and having a robust sense of teacher identity, mentors should continually strive to instil confidence in preservice teachers and create a sense of self-worth and positive self-image in them. One way to enhance their confidence is to help them find a teacher voice. Although preservice teachers might need to be spoon-fed with all the details and information as they start teaching, they need to be in control and have the liberty to try out their ideas as they progress. Mentor teachers should give them different roles to play and responsibilities to undertake and constantly encourage them to generate ideas so they dare to have a voice and contribute ideas.

As the present study indicates, all preservice teachers had clear expectations about the mentoring relationship prior to the program. For some, having the freedom to test their teaching ideas freely in the classroom was very significant; for others, being consistently supported mattered the most. In other words, preservice teachers have different expectations of the program and need different sorts of help depending on their personalities, background experiences, and future needs. Ideally, mentor teachers, at the outset of the program, should try to ascertain their mentees' wants, needs and expectations. As also observed in this study, preservice teachers lack real power in the classroom (Patrick, 2013) and they may shy away from expressing their ideas and feelings when experiencing any tensions or conflicts, thereby negatively impacting their learning and perceptions of themselves as teachers (Axford, 2005). Thus, mentor teachers should also provide a supportive context through maintaining a non-hierarchical relationship, in which preservice teachers are eagerly

listened to so they feel free to discuss their views.

It is not enough for mentors to be eager and willing to facilitate preservice teachers' professional development; mentors will achieve little if they are ill prepared for their role (He, 2009). Teacher education programs can screen mentor teachers according to their attitude and character, professional competence and experience, and communication and interpersonal skills (NFIE (National Foundation for the Improvement of Education), 1999). The next step for teacher education is to prepare the selected mentor teachers for their mentoring task through in-depth training programs designed to develop their mentoring skills and heighten their awareness of their key roles and responsibilities. In some states in Australia such as NSW and some countries like the UK there are mentor training programs designed to prepare mentor teachers for their mentoring role (Bignold & Barbera, 2012; Rodrigo et al., 2014). For instance, in Europe, a project named TISSNTE (Teacher Induction: Supporting the Supporters of Novice Teachers in Europe) was designed to develop a mentor training program for European mentors (Jones, 2009). Yet, in other contexts such as Western Australia and Turkey scant attention has been paid to preparation programs for mentor teachers (Aslan & Öcal, 2012; Tok, 2013). This research calls for the inclusion of rigorous mentor training programs within teacher education in all contexts and more research on what constitutes mentor training. It is hypothesized that mentor teachers receiving adequate training would be better prepared and have more effective impact on preservice teachers' professional development.

Acknowledgement

I am grateful to all preservice teachers who participated in this research and provided continued support during the data collection. I am also truly thankful to Dr John Hall for reading and commenting on earlier drafts of this paper.

Appendix

Preservice Teachers' Interview Framework.

(First Round)

1. What made you choose teaching as a career? What is your purpose of teaching?
2. What do you perceive as your main responsibilities as a teacher toward yourself and your students?
3. Do you have a vision of the kind of teacher you would like to be?
4. What metaphor would you use to represent yourself as a future teacher at this time? Could you explain?
5. What changes might you anticipate in your image of yourself as a future teacher? What might influence these changes?
6. What might make you stay in teaching? What might lead you to leave it?
7. How do you think your mentor's role should be? (Parent figure/support system.) Why do you think so?
8. How do you imagine your relationship with your mentor teachers develops during this year? Can you use another metaphor to describe this perceived relationship? (You could start like this: My relationship with my mentor would be like … .
9. To what extent do you think the relationship you have with your mentors will affect you and your vision of the teacher you want to be?

(Second Round)

1. How do you now perceive your identity as a teacher?
   - Describe any specific changes in your teacher identity since you began your practicum?
2. Is there a metaphor, you could use that best represents your teacher identity at this stage?
3. To what extent have you been able to find your teacher voice?
   - If you have been able to develop your teacher voice, what do you contribute it to?
   - If you have not been able to develop your teacher voice, what do you contribute it to?
4. Describe the characteristics of the relationship you shared with your mentor teacher?
5. What metaphor would best describe your mentoring relationship?
   - Is it the same as before?
   - Or, if it is different, please elaborate?
6. With respect to your relationship with your mentor teacher:
   - What things would you like to change?
   - What things would you like to keep the same?
7. Has your mentor teacher changed your vision of 'the teacher you want to be'? If so:
   - What things have changed?
   - What things have remained the same?
8. During your practicum were there any significant experiences that you encountered?
   - Describe these experiences.
   - How did these specific experiences affect you?
   - How did you deal with these specific experiences?
9. To what extent did your mentor teacher facilitate the personal resolve and confidence you needed during your practicum?
   - Describe the context and the facilitation role played by your mentor teacher.
   - How did this affect your resolve and confidence?
   - What would you want to change about this type of facilitation?
   - What would you keep the same about this facilitation?
10. To what extent has your mentor teacher met your expectations about mentoring?
    - Describe a mentoring situation that exceeded your expectations.
    - Describe a mentoring situation that fell short of your expectations.

(Third Round)

1. What do you perceive as your main responsibilities as a teacher toward yourself and your students at this stage?
2. What changes have you noticed in your image of yourself as a teacher? Any changes in your confidence? Voice? Vision?
3. What metaphor would you use to represent yourself as a teacher at this time?
4. How significant was the role of your mentor teachers in changing your teacher identity?
5. Can you compare the relationship you shared with your mentors in the first and second practicum? Which one did you prefer and why?
6. Which of your practicum experiences was more influential in shaping your teacher identity, why?
7. Was there any critical experiences, including tensions you have lived through during the second Practicum?
8. Do you think your mentor could give you the courage and confidence you needed in your role?
9. How has your second mentor met your expectations about how a mentor teacher would (or should) be?

10. What factors do you think played the most significant role in shaping your teacher identity? Your university lecturer? Your mentors? School context? etc?

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